

# NEW GUINEA MONTANE FOREST

Remote tropical highlands form a biodiversity stronghold

Situated almost on the equator, New Guinea is the world's second-largest island. Politically it is divided into two halves: Indonesia in the west and Papua New Guinea in the east. The island's biodiversity, among the richest in the world, is a blend of Australian and Asian wildlife, which arrived here hundreds of thousands of years ago before the continents and New Guinea diverged.

## Protected by terrain

Despite two centuries of encroachment by logging, agriculture, livestock, and mineral exploitation—which is persistently increasing—around two-thirds of New Guinea is still cloaked in forest, due mainly to the island's inaccessibly mountainous terrain. The upland forests are broadly organized into the Vogelkop (Bird's Head) montane rainforests in the northwest Doberai Peninsula, the Central Ranges rainforests along the backbone of the

island, and the Huon Peninsula rainforests in the northwest. The moist, tropical climate encourages riotous growth. Populations of plants and animals, isolated in steep, remote valleys and on scattered peaks, have evolved into thousands of species found nowhere else on the planet.

Active volcanoes and earthquakes continue to create new land forms, encouraging further diversity. So does altitude; lower hills are hot and steamy, while taller peaks are cooler and cloud-shrouded. These forests harbor more than 6,000 plant species and dozens of unique birds and mammals, including egg-laying echidnas and marsupials such as tree-kangaroos.



HOODED PITOHI

**POISONOUS BIRD**  
Tests in the late 1980s showed that the hooded pitohui's skin and feathers exude the nerve poison homobatrachotoxin, which causes numbness and tingling if touched by humans. Furthermore, the toxin has since been found in other pitohui species.

Dozens of new species found here each year

**BOWER BUILDER**  
The Vogelkop bowerbird assembles a highly designed structure, or bower, of twigs, stems, and leaves decorated with flowers, shells, and other bright items. All his effort is aimed at one thing: to impress females enough to attract a mate.



VOGELKOP BOWERBIRD

Home to all four echidna species

## POCKET PREDATOR

Dasyures are Australasian carnivorous marsupials, such as the quoll and Tasmanian devil. One of the smallest is New Guinea's speckled dasyure, a Central Ranges inhabitant that hunts various species of insects, worms, and grubs.

SPECKLED DASYURE